early 1960s to the present, and several of my closest friends were personally involved from the 1930s onward. I have tried to balance my resulting bias by extensive taped interviews with other participants in the quest (see the bibliography) and by running chapters past some of them (see the acknowledgments). However, some bias surely remains.

As an aid to the reader who wants greater completeness, accuracy, and impartiality, I have listed in the notes at the back of the book the sources for many of the text's historical statements, and references to some of the original technical articles that the quest's participants have written to explain their discoveries to each other. The notes also contain more precise (and therefore more technical) discussions of some issues that are distorted in the text by my striving for simplicity.

Memories are fallible; different people, experiencing the same events, may interpret and remember them in very different ways. I have relegated such differences to the notes. In the text, I have stated my own final view of things as though it were gospel. May real historians forgive me, and may nonhistorians thank me.

John Wheeler, my principal mentor and teacher during my formative years as a physicist (and a central character in this book), delights in asking his friends, "What is the single most important thing you have learned about thus and so?" Few questions focus the mind so clearly. In the spirit of John's question, I ask myself, as I come to the end of fifteen years of on-and-off writing (mostly off), "What is the single most important thing that you want your readers to learn?"

My answer: the amazing power of the human mind—by fits and starts, blind alleys, and leaps of insight—to unravel the complexities of our Universe, and reveal the ultimate simplicity, the elegance, and the glorious beauty of the fundamental laws that govern it